happen. (*He inserts the parcel lengthwise into the pail, at full stretch of his arm, his head averted, his eyes watching from their extreme corners*) There is not enough water! Not enough to cover it.

ROGER: I'll get some. I shall not be a moment.

WESTON: No. Don't go. The flowers! (*He indicates a bowl of daffodils*).

ROGER: Of course! (*He pulls the daffodils from their setting, throwing them on the desk in his agitation and pours the water into the pail*). Ah! That has done it!

WESTON (*dismayed, as he takes his hand from the package*): Now it is going to float! It must be wet through, or it is no use.

ROGER: We must put something heavy on top, to keep it down.

WESTON: Yes, yes. Get something.

ROGER: What shall I get?

WESTON: Anything, anything that is heavy and that will fit into the pail. Books, anything!

ROGER (*to whom books are objects of reverence, if not awe*): Books sir? But they'll get very wet, won't they?

WESTON: In the name of heaven bring the first six books off the shelf!

ROGER (*snatching the books and bringing them*): I suppose it cannot be helped. Such beautiful bindings too! (*He picks the wet cloth off the edge of the pail, dropping it on the carpet, and plunges the books into the water, which very naturally overflows at this new incursion*).

WESTON (*letting go his hold on the package and siting back on his heels with a sigh of relief*): Ah! Well and truly drowned. (*He mops his forehead and ROGER collapses into the nearest chair*).

(*Enter LADY WESTON, with a tray on which is a glass of wine and some biscuits.*)

LADY WESTON (*seeing their strange occupation*): Richard! What have you got in the pail?

WESTON: A package that came this morning. The man who brought it was the same fellow that knocked against me yesterday and slipped that paper into my pocket. They thought I would open it, the fools! (*He is beginning to feel better*) But we have been one too many for them!

LADY WESTON (*in wild dismay*)You are making a mess of the beautiful, brand-new----

WESTON (*interrupting her angrily*): Frances! (*The thunder of her name quenches her speech.*) What does your 'beautiful brand-new' carpet matter when your husband's life is at stake? You shock me.

LADY WESTON (*who was not going to say 'carpet'*): Carpet? (After a pause, mildly) No, of course not, my dear. I should never dream of weighing your safety against even the finest product of Asia. You know how the doctor disapproves of excitement for you.

WESTON: Perhaps the doctor has never had an **infernal** machine handed in at his door of a spring morning.

LADY WESTON (*contemplative, her eyes on the portrait which hangs opposite the*

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